cylinder, cube or pyramid. Next, drag anywhere in the viewport, to create a sphere in 3D space.

Once you have created a sphere, you can then look on the right side at the Channels Box – this will no longer be blank. The new values it contains are related to the selected object, which in this case is the sphere.

After creating the sphere, hit the hot key [W] on your keyboard and you'll see a tool that's pointing in various directions. Try left-clicking one of the three arrows and move it around. You'll notice that the object moves, and the translate x, y and z values in the Channel Box change. The translation values tell you where the object sits in Maya's 3D space. Now try hitting [E] – this will display four rings around the object which are basically for x, y and z rotation. Similarly, when you press [R], you can scale the object accordingly.

Now that you have created an object and are familiar with the Channel Box, let's see how to change the segments of the shape.

In the Channel Box, under the values for Translate, Rotation, Scale and Visibility, you'll see a section called SHAPES with a subsection called INPUTS. Here, you will find polySphere1. Click on this to see how the selected mesh or geometry has been created.

In this example, it's a polygon sphere and there are no other polygon spheres in the scene, hence the name polySphere1. If you click on a value such as Radius, it becomes editable so that you can change the size of the radius according to your needs. The Subdivision Axis and Height are the curves that you see around the geometry. If you change any of these values, you will see these changes reflected in the mesh.

Hotkeys: There are a number of hotkeys in Maya and you can further customise the list. The basic ones are:

Common Hotkeys used in Maya:

[F1] Maya Help
[F2] Animation menu
[F3] Modelling menu
[F4] Surfaces menu
[1] Rough NURBS smooth/Actual polygonal preview
[2] Medium NURBS smooth/Polygonal smooth mesh display
[3] Fine NURBS smooth/Polygonal smooth preview
[4] Wireframe mode
[5] Shaded mode
[6] Hardware texturing